



POST-WAR PERFECTION

Cecil Beaton's 1948 photograph of stunning evening gowns by leading American couturier Charles James encapsulates the heady optimism and return to glamour of post-war New York. Wartime closures of French *maisons* and tight post-war travel budgets had turned influential US magazine editors towards home-grown design. A vibrant scene of high society and fashionable clubs, along with a rapidly strengthening economy, gave American designers a further boost. New York had become a rising fashion location.

Eveningwear in the late 1940s and 1950s by designers such as Dior, Balenciaga, and Balmain revelled in copious fabric and the glamorized, old-fashioned feminine ideal. English-born James, widely considered the only true US couturier, was said to have inspired Dior's New Look silhouette, the ultimate antidote to wartime utility.

James was an obsessive perfectionist, best known for dressing socialites in fabulously expensive, dramatic gowns. These intricately constructed sculptures, fabricating a perfect post-war woman, were art forms in their own right. James used boning and multiple layers of silk, satin, taffeta, and tulle to build 19th-century-influenced gowns with expressive shapes and complex seamlines, spiral draping and wrapping, asymmetric features, light-catching materials, and differently coloured layers that flashed as the wearer glided across a room. Totally self-supporting, these hourglass garments tightly moulded and defined the torso, before exploding into vast skirts reminiscent of butterfly and swans' wings or four-leaved clovers.

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America's greatest couturier, the world's best and only dressmaker who has raised it from an applied art to a pure art form.

CRISTOBAL BALENCIAGA ON CHARLES JAMES

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◀ “HIGH-SOCIETY” TABLEAU

Poised *Vogue* models imitate a high-society scene in an elegant, neoclassical New York interior. Narcissistically checking themselves in mirrors or touching their fashionably showy jewellery, they are more like statues than real women, representing subtle variations of a feminine ideal.